

Retrospective on Data Center Opposition in Starkville

*What We Did... Therefore, What **YOU** Can Do!*

The Basics

During the period of late June to early August of 2026 (about 2 months), residents in Starkville, MS and the surrounding area organized to oppose a crypto mining facility (a type of data center) that was proposed to be built in the city. That effort was successful, as the facility was denied by the Planning and Zoning commission on August 11, and the proposing company pulled their own special exemption application from consideration before the subsequent Board of Aldermen meeting.

This document is an attempt to provide a sort of blueprint for potential organizers and community members in our area and beyond. We can't guarantee the exact same strategies will work everywhere, so please use your discernment to take what works and leave what doesn't. Also, **do not try to do all of this yourself, divide and conquer!**

If you would like a more thorough breakdown, please see the full retrospective report [HERE](#).

Know Thy Battlefield

Before you can do anything, you need to find out the steps that will be taken to actually build the facility. This ensures you know who you need to convince and when, and it will likely require getting involved with your local government and learning its processes.

If you live in an area **with zoning regulations**, those are a great target for opposition. Many places do not have existing zoning policies for data centers, so opposition can target that as a reason to not allow the facility. If the company has to go through a

special exemption process (as ours did), you can lobby the Planning & Zoning department to deny the permit for any number of reasons (as we did).

If you live in an area **without zoning regulations**, your task may be more difficult. You may need to lobby the leaders of your town/city directly to block construction of the facility. Find out who the decisionmaker(s) are for the land sale, construction, etc. and try to get them on your side, or perhaps protest the construction itself. The “Know Thy Neighbor” section may be most useful for you if you need to organize a protest.

Regardless of the structure of your local government, it is crucial to **find out when your local leaders meet and show up in-person to voice your concerns**. Always remember that your leaders/board members/etc. are your neighbors too, so please stay empathetic and respectful. Get in the town square and get loud (respectfully)!

Know Thy Enemy

One of the most critical parts of this effort is research. Depending on your local government structure, you may have a different research path than we did.

Here are a few questions to get you started:

- What is being proposed or built, and where?
- Who is trying to build it? Where is their company located, and who owns it?
 - o OpenCorporates is a good resource: <https://opencorporates.com/>
- What process do they have to go through, and where are they in the process?
 - o Research local government policies/procedures
- Does the company operate any other similar facilities?
 - o In our case, we found these in a Board of Aldermen work session
- If there are other facilities by the same company, can you get in touch with any residents of that area? What do they think?

Research should be as fact-based as possible; avoid opinion pieces unless they're testimonials of someone's lived experience near a similar facility. Some of this

information may be buried in public documents online or within your local government. Don't be afraid to reach out to public officials directly for information.

Know Thy Neighbor

It takes a village to oppose things like this. You will need to find people sympathetic to the cause and build an opposition group, perhaps through networking in existing community structures (churches, clubs, etc.). This can be daunting, but also rewarding!

A great way to start finding other opposed individuals is to speak out at local government meetings and events (board meetings, town halls, etc.) and watch out for others speaking up. If there are like-minded people, meet up with them afterwards and keep in touch.

Group Chats

Group chats are very useful. You could use a variety of communication channels including simple text chats, GroupMe, Facebook groups, Discord, or even Signal if you're concerned about privacy. Please keep in mind that this will be an intergenerational effort... try to pick something that even older community members can engage with.

We started with a small text chat with a handful of people. As the group grew, we moved to GroupMe and used the topics feature to make it easier to have multiple conversations about different topics at once. For example, we had the main chat and breakout topics like these: Company Identity, Pollution (Noise/Heat/Air), Utilities (Electricity/Water). Your topics may vary based on what people in your community are concerned about; just keep an eye on the conversation, and if something is a frequent topic it may warrant its own section.

In-Person Events

It's also extremely helpful to **have some in-person events to build community** amongst those who are opposed. This can be smaller meetings focused on research and speech/comment writing or larger meetings focused on informing the community

about what has been learned and what needs to be done. It's worth asking around in your communities to see if anyone has a space that could be used for cheap or even free, such as a church fellowship hall or even an outdoor space.

For example, we had some smaller breakoff groups that met to discuss, research, and write speeches for the Planning & Zoning hearing. We also had a "Community Conversations" potluck event the day before the hearing to get as many people as possible on the same page about the facility and how the hearing would work. This was also an opportunity to discuss effective speechwriting tactics and the importance of not being antagonistic (remember, board members are your neighbors too!).

Spreading the Word

To increase your turnout for major events like hearings and therefore the impact of the opposition, you need to talk to your family, friends, coworkers, and others about them. If they're completely supportive of the development, it may not be helpful (or good for the relationship) to try to convince them, but if they're on the fence it may be worth trying.

In any case, you can take a somewhat "neutral" approach and simply tell people when and where important meetings/hearings will be. This could mean spreading the word about a Board of Aldermen meeting so people can provide comments, or it could be putting up flyers about the most critical events, like the Planning & Zoning hearing in our case. Your goal is to have as many people in the room for important meetings as possible to show that **this is something your community cares enough about to show up and speak out!**

In Conclusion

If you're facing a data center project in your region, opposition is no easy task. It requires research, commitment, and (perhaps most importantly) community. You'll have to be sincere about your beliefs/concerns in front of people you have never met, reach across ideological lines to build coalitions, and delegate so no one gets burnt out. But the success of our opposition shows that **it is possible, no matter what anyone says.**

We hope this document is helpful for you. This is not an all-encompassing list, only what we found to work in our situation. **Be creative and find what works for your community!**